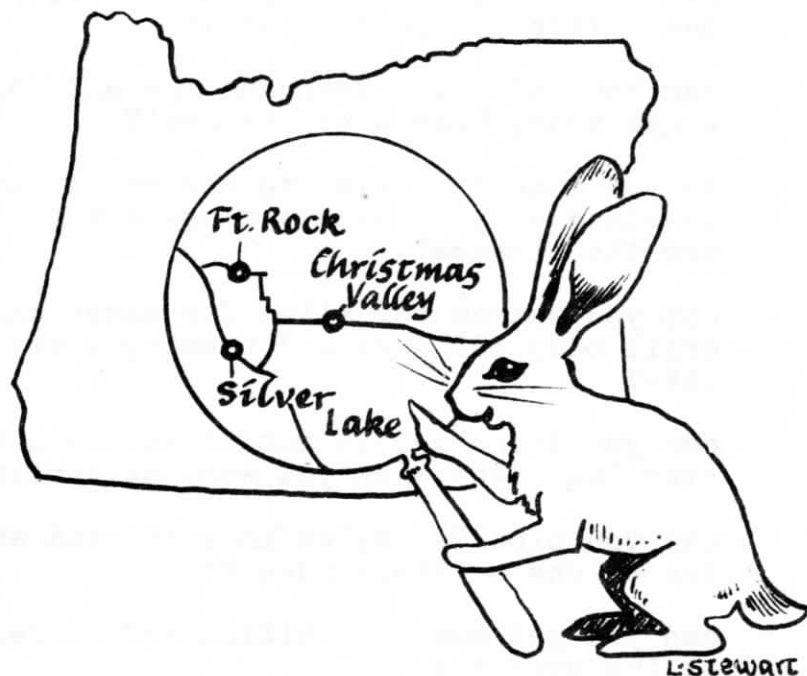


DESERT WHISPERS

50¢
a copy

Special Edition



FIRST DAY ISSUE
PUTS CHRISTMAS VALLEY
ON MAP

October 28, 1981

WELCOME TO UNIQUE CHRISTMAS VALLEY

WHERE ELSE: but around Christmas Valley could you find a Silver Lake that is green pastures or a Fort Rock that never has been a fort?

but near Christmas Valley can you walk thru a Crack in the Ground, explore the bottom of a Christmas Lake, find fish vertebrae and sea shells on a desert floor, or examine other fossils and arrowheads around a Fossil Lake?

could you get lost in a Lost Forest, get stuck on a sand dune, gaze with wonder at the holes in a Woodpecker House and search, without luck, for miles for a single tree?

can you still see a real cattle drive and have to fence the cattle out instead of in?

can you watch the deer and the antelope play, see an eagle soar, hear a coyote howl?

do you come for miles to see the desert bloom but have to stand on your head and use a magnifying glass to see the blossom?

can you search for miles for water and see none, but drill only 100 feet and seemingly hit an underground lake?

can you think you've got it made and then have to go over 1000 feet when you want an irrigation well?

can you plod for miles in soft sand and then stub your toe on one solitary huge rock?

can you get mosquito bitten and suffer from dehydration at the same time?

can Juniper forests look like tall pines and an unseen building loom like a skyscraper or at night Christmas Valley seem like a huge line of lighted candles?

could a dust devil catch you as you creep over rutted, mud filled roads---and have your hair turn to straw, your face to leather and your temper to molten lava?

WHERE ELSE: is the quiet deafening, the sunsets spectacular, the stars sparkling and, if the wind is blowing, the fall-out constant without a volcano eruption?

WELCOME TO THE PLACE LIKE NO OTHER PLACE, OREGON'S BEAUTIFUL HIGH DESERT AND CHRISTMAS VALLEY.

CHRISTMAS LAKE NAMED BY MAPPING ERROR ?

CHRISTMAS VALLEY is a 70,000 acre development in North Lake County. It is almost twice the size of the District of Columbia and was formerly a portion of the famed ZX brand ranch properties of Sinton and Brown of La Pine, Oregon. The M. Penn Phillips Company is primary developer.

" The naming of Christmas Valley seems to be a mapping error in the early days. John C. Fremont, in 1843, came off Winter Ridge (Summer Lake Rim) into Summer Lake Valley and proceeded over to the head of Abert Lake and on East across the Hog Back to Warner Valley.

Fremont's map and notes of the area designate present day Hart Lake as Christmas Lake where they apparently were on Christmas Day. Later maps from 1860's on seem to have moved the Christmas Lake name from Warner Valley to the Fort Rock basin.

Present day Christmas Lake seems to have been filled in the late 1860's as the miners travelling from the Yreka-Jacksonville mines to the John Day Gold Strike were forced to go over Picture Rock Pass to bypass the water running out of Silver Lake and into the Christmas Valley Lake bed. This may have some significance as the lake would have been a major landmark." Above according to Jack Pendleton, Lake County Historical Society.

Christmas Valley is located on a broad, level plateau Southeast of Bend and Northeast of Klamath Falls, at an elevation of 4300 ft. It was started in 1961 by the M. Penn Phillips Company which was headed by M. Penn Phillips, the pioneer of western land developments. According to
(continued on page 2)

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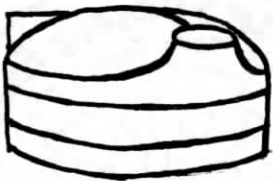
the March 1962 Christmas Valley Gazette, "a list of communities that he has either started from nothing, or had a share of, reads like a "Who's Who" in the western recreational and residential development field. Mr. Phillips, a native Oklahoman, came to California in 1923. His first project was the development of Clear Lake, California."...After 38 years of developing different communities in the western United States, "he was now an old hand at watching communities grow under his hand from infants to self-supporting towns and cities. He was surprised at the rapid acceptance by the public of this, his latest development, Christmas Valley. He predicted to his associates as early as 1959 that retirement cities would prove extremely popular with older citizens, as well as younger people. Christmas Valley has borne out that prediction, and he feels that our Valley might well prove to be the most successful project he has ever started.

Such is the history of the Christmas Valley Development Company."

TOWN GROWS

The first grocery store was opened in 1962 by Al and Connie Baert and since that time there has opened another grocery store, 3 trailer courts, 2 motels, 3 restaurants, farm equipment company, real estate agents, well drillers, yardage store, gift shop, backhoe and septic services, game arcade, building supply, construction contractors, welding shop, Tupperware dealer, bookkeeping service, irrigation dealers, aviation and automotive services, feed store, salvage yard and auto parts stores under construction and laundromat. There are approximately 50 business at the present time.

(continued on page 3)



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By Dolores

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Grammar schools with classes from the first to the eighth grades, are located in Fort Rock and Silver Lake. High school students travel to Paisley. School bus service is available.

There are four churches in the Valley, namely: Seventh Day Adventist, Community Church - interdenominational, Catholic and Assembly of God Church.

There are 391 registered voters in our community.

POST OFFICE OPENS IN 1962

THE CHRISTMAS VALLEY POST OFFICE opened in 1962 with Barbara Baert as Clerk in Charge. It was lodged in what is now Goeres Grocery and remained there until September 1978. Back then it was only 35¢ to rent a box, according to Connie Baert, who took over in 1964 and ran it until 1969.



Connie Baert in the
Post Office

In May of 1969, Betty Goeres became Clerk in Charge and maintained the post until 1974 when Kathryn McClister took over until 1975.

From 1975 to September of 1978, Betty Goeres again ran the Post Office.

Dorothy Garrison then took over the Post Office and it was moved into
(continued on page 4)

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the building next to Pettus Realty office, which is now John's office. Four months later Dorothy moved the Post Office to the north side of the Christmas Valley Highway just east of the west cattle guard.

In 1979 Irene Corey took over until 1980, when the present Clerk in Charge, Juanita Richards took over. After one month's time, Juanita moved into the present Post Office building between Valley Foods Store and Valley Business Center.

AREAS OF INTEREST VARIED IN VALLEY

The Christmas Valley area has several areas of interest surrounding the Valley. They include the Sand Dunes, The Black Hills, Crack in the Ground, Fossil Lake and Lost Forest. The following information is from the Bureau of Land Management and Raymond R. Hatton's High Desert of Central Oregon.

THE SAND DUNES is a 10,000 acre tract that has been designated as a wilderness study area. It has been a favorite spot for dune buggy enthusiasts for sometime and though a study area, it is open to off road vehicles from boundaries of Fossil Lake to the boundary of the Lost Forest Research Natural Area.

THE BLACK HILLS encompasses an area of 1,740 acres. It is closed to off road travel but two access roads are open for those who enjoy walking or riding horseback.

The area is closed to protect a rare plant called the "Cusicks Buckwheat." It is found in only two other locations in the world - near Burns and near the Steens Mountains.

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FOSSIL LAKE - The fossils at Fossil Lake are 10,000 to 2 million years old. The animals found are mammoths, sloths, camels, flamingos, pelicans, salmon and snails.

The area is closed to all vehicles as the fossils are extremely fragile and it is illegal to collect or destroy them. Findings are supposed to be left at the site.

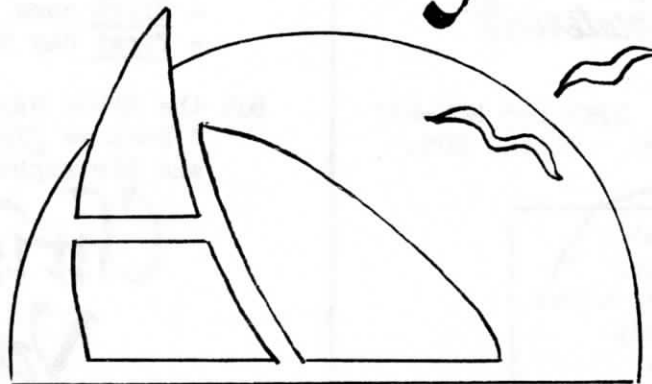
The "Way West" movie was partially filmed at Fossil Lake and the Sand Dunes in the late 1960's

THE LOST FOREST is a Research Natural Area and was designated so in 1972. The area has a stand of Ponderosa Pine that grows in an arid climate which is dependant on the peculiar soil conditions that are present. The area has some of the largest Juniper trees in Oregon.

This stand of Pine trees is 40 miles from any main stand of Ponderosa Pines. It probably is a remnant of an extensive pine forest that at one time covered much of Central Oregon. As the climate became more arid the desert took over except for what is now Lost Forest. Lost Forest gets only 8 inches of rain fall per year and normally it takes 18 to 20 inches of precipitation to support Ponderosa Pine.

Vehicles are allowed on designated roads but not off the roads.

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CRACK IN THE GROUND is a fissure or crack in the ground that one may walk through. A rare geologic phenomenon, it is nearly 1,000 years old and runs 2 miles and reaches a depth of 70 feet. In some places snow remains all summer in the crack. Winter ice is preserved in dryer parts where cold air is trapped.

Looking down into
West end of Crack in
the Ground



Crack in the Ground is a
day use area and has a restroom and parking site.

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- first come first served
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But the Bible says,

" Seek ye first the Kingdom of God
and His righteousness—" Math. 6:33

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Sunday 10 & 11 AM
Everyone Welcome

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PIONEERING, WAY OF LIFE SINCE EARLY 1900'S

HOMESTEADING IN THE EARLY 1900's

In the early 1900's homesteaders flocked onto the lands in the Christmas Lake Valley to claim up to 320 acres under the Enlarged Homestead Act of 1909. From the August 7, 1910 Oregonian, came the account, "Christmas Lake Valley, Lake County's largest single area of tillable land, is being rapidly settled. People are pouring into Lakeview on every stage, auto and other conveyance that is possible to secure. In 12 townships which had less than half a dozen settlers four years ago, there are now in the neighborhood of 1,000 entries made on 160 and 320 acre homesteads."

And so they came with high hopes and determination to carve a home and livelihood out of the sagebrush covered land. They built small, simple cabins, some from the Juniper forests nearby. By burning or hand grubbing or both, they cleared the land of sagebrush, plowed and planted their dry land crops such as rye, wheat, barley, peas, potatoes and alfalfa.

Rainfall was relatively heavy and the growing season long in 1911 and 1912. Encouraging crops were taken. In 1913 the growing season dropped to 55 days. Wind erosion tore at the tilled soil. Rabbits and rodents demolished their already thin crops. Unsurmountable problems plagued the settlers.

Railroads were promised but never came. The cost of transporting the crops to a market was a problem. A period of drought started in 1915. Major irrigation systems were proposed but never developed. The settlers considered drilling their own wells but the costs of the equipment and
(continued on page 8)



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it's fuel made those ideas prohibitive.

By 1916 and the beginning of World War I, most high hopes had turned to broken dreams. Wages in urban areas enticed many of the settlers from the area. The drop in farm prices beginning with the Agricultural depression of 1920 hastened many more off the land. Many could or would not pay their property taxes and so their lands went back to the governments. The Federal Government bought additional acres under the Bankhead-Jones Act in the late 1930's.

Little remains to mark these early homesteading endeavors. A few boards, rusting metals, broken glass and patches of wind blown, eroded soil can be found on the again sagebrush covered valley. Does the occasionally howling wind tell of the ache of all those lost dreams?

THE PIONEER SPIRIT REAWAKENED IN THE 1970's

Electricity did not come to the area until the 1950's, with it came the means to irrigate the dry high desert lands. In the 1960's Penn Phillips, land developers, built the Christmas Valley Lodge, the man made lake and golf course and began selling town lots and parcels of land through out the valley. It wasn't until the late '70's that interest in farming the land reawakened with zeal.

Instead of horse-drawn wagons bringing in all the family's possessions today big tractor trucks pull mobile homes onto the sage and rabbit brush covered land. Until they get electricity and water, these new
(continued on page 9)



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pioneers laugh as they revert back to doing things as their predecessors did in olden days.

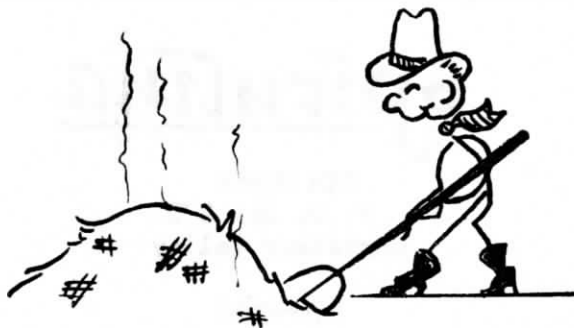
With their dreams of turning their land into seas of green, these people tackle the job of clearing their property. They use brush beaters that look like huge lawn mowers to beat the sagebrush down. The residue is either burned or rototilled under to eventually add needed humus to the soil.

Everything depends on getting water onto the dry desert soil. When their wells are drilled, these families hold their breathes. Well depths may vary from under 100 feet in a few areas to over 1000 feet in a few others! They may end up spending their fortune on just their wells! Probably the first thrill of their desert lives is watching an abundant, non-alkaline irrigation well come in!

The next thrill may be watching their installed irrigation equipment put the water on their land. Quarter-mile-long pivots dot the countryside. These irrigation systems turn on an axis and circle the fields automatically. Rainbows dance amongst their water droplets. Hope runs high that these rainbows are prophecies of plentiful crops to come.

Once the land has been cleared, the wells drilled, power installed and irrigation systems set up, the land is fenced with barbed wire and then prepared for planting. First the land is leveled. Puffing cata-

(continued on page 10)



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pillars or tractor-pulled land levelers smooth what originally seemed fairly flat land. The sand accumulation around each sagebrush plant proves to be considerable with each encounter. Giant toothed rippers break up the hard-pan crust that has formed about 18 inches to 3 feet beneath the surface. Breaking the crust allows irrigation water to penetrate freely.

The sandy loamed soil works beautifully by rototiller or disc. Caught in spring winds however, acres can be moved on across the desert before it can be wet down. Dust devils and dust storms are probably as prevalent now as they were in homestead days. A busy housewife laments, "You can write in the dust in my home, but please don't date it."

Crops are planted and nitrogen and other needed fertilizers are applied. Balloon wheeled swamp buggies are sometimes used to put on dry fertilizer. The irrigation systems themselves can be used for liquid fertilizers.

The third thrill for these new pioneers is to see their acres turn a bright green as their crops immerge and flourish. Here, too, they hold their breathes. They have to guess the growing season. They have to plant late enough to avoid the late spring frosts but early enough to avoid the early fall frosts. Home gardens and field crops alike can get nipped any day of the year at 4300 foot elevation.

Once their crops are up, the newcomers, like the old homesteaders may find the beautiful native animals are suddenly the ugly enemy. The
(continued on page 11)

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ALL KINDS OF DOLLS

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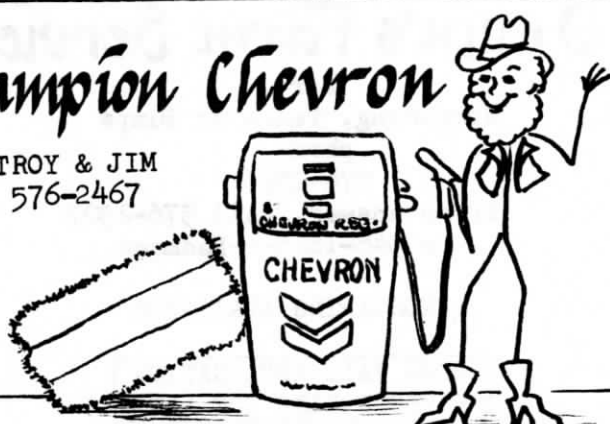
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jackrabbits, whose numbers seem to change in cycles, can do real havoc to alfalfa and grain fields. Coyotes, to the novice, should be permitted to roam to keep down the rabbit population. When they take off with the family dog or cat or a flock of chickens for their supper, they suddenly become less tolerable. To a tried and true cattleman or sheepman who have

(continued on page 12)

The cattle industry has long been important in the Valley. Open range laws prevail. ZX brand cattle are again in the local area. ZX Ranch recently purchased former Viewpoint holdings.

At right, cattle drive at the corner of Christmas Valley Road and Christmas Tree Lane.

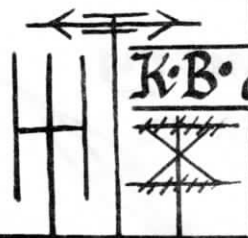


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witnessed how they appease their natural instincts for survival amongst their livestock, the coyotes are real arch enemies. Many a resident is torn as they balance their love of the sight of the deer and antelope on down to the kangaroo rats and chipmunks and their desire to keep their garden growing.

When harvest finally comes, it is hectic! Everyone gets involved! It's women's lib, kid's lib and friends and relatives from the city, too, are at liberty to help bring in the crops.

The fourth thrill for these farming people is watching their hay stacks pile up or seeing their grain hauled to market. But at this point the thrill may be dulled as they calculate what the crop has cost them. They don't know if they are going to make a fortune but they know they've spent one! Costs of mortgages, interest, equipment and repairs, fertilizer, fuel and energy have risen so drastically in the last few years, by the time harvest comes in, they hold their breaths hoping they will break even.

As they join the multitude of farmers all over the country, getting small pay for their high risks and long hours, they must be tempted to sell out and move where there is higher pay as their predecessors did before them. But jobs are scarce and life is more complicated in the cities. Life on the Oregon High Desert becomes a habit hard to break. They get hooked on the beauty they have discovered: the spectacular sun-
(continued on page 13)

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risers and sunsets, the sparkling night stars, the broad open horizon, the limitless and ever-changing sky, the animals, the peaceful quiet, the friendly people and the opportunity to create and hold onto something they've done with their own hands, with their own work.

Some will probably leave. Others will replace them. They and those that have stayed will meet the challenge of taming the desert. There will probably be frustrations, tears and disappointments. With determination and a sense of humor, they will conquer adversity. With ingenuity and hard work they will combat the short growing season and inflation. With patience and perseverance they will listen and the wind will howl, this time for joy and this new frontier will be reclaimed.

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~Desert Life~

- Sagebrush Sam and Desert Rabbit were buddies in Christmas Valley -

They just by chance happened one day to meet on Snowflake Alley.

Said Sagebrush Sam to Desert Rabbit as they passed that day,

"By the way, my ruts were filled by Howard's truck today.

Come rain or snow, Yep! - and hail or storm,
my pivot wheels, I reckon, will stay airborne!

Now when city folk come pivot prospectin, they'll take a good look
at my field, I'm expectin."

- Said Desert Rabbit to Sagebrush Sam, "I'm a tired of everythin' gettin'
in a sham! So gimme that name, and gimme that number,
my pivot wheels ain't gonna go under."

- So off into the sunset their pick-ups did roar... each the wiser for havin' learned more.

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- Darrell -

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Our thanks to Al and Connie Baert
and John and Evelyn Pettus for the
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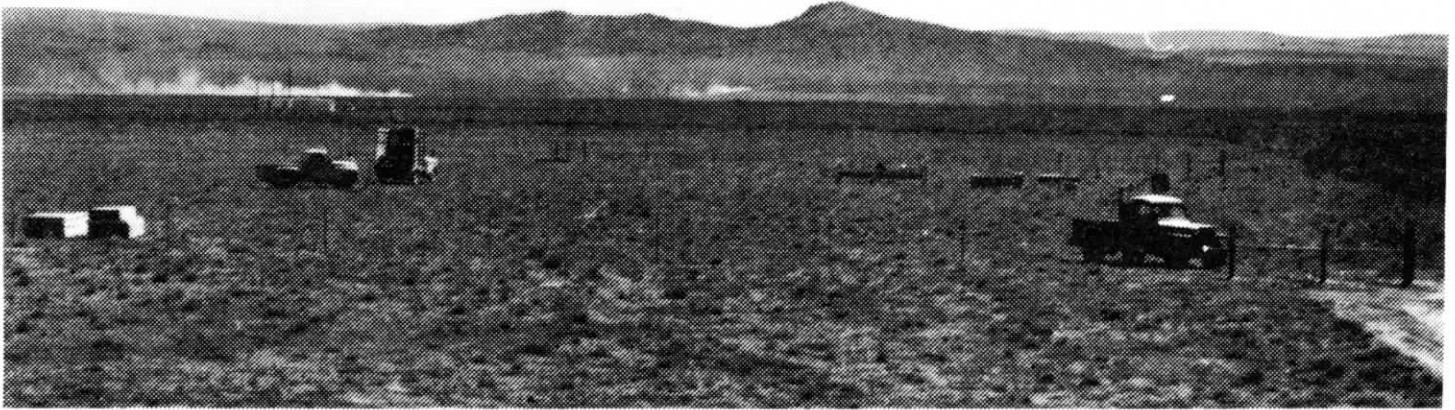
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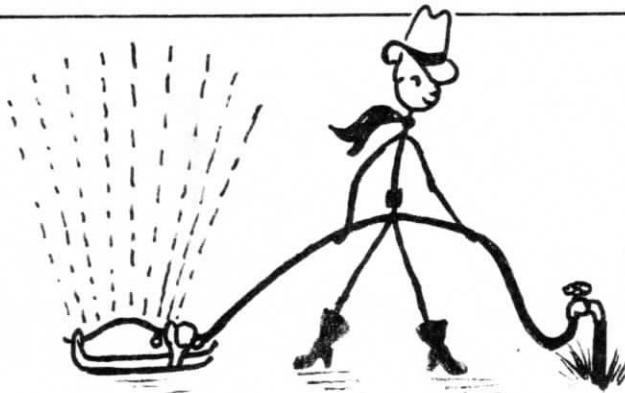
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